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OUR HOPE THAT THE EVACUATION of PLO forces from Lebanon would mark the beginning of a new and comprehensive peace process and a first step toward a final resolution of the great problems bedeviling the Middle East went up in the smoke of a terrorist bomb three weeks after the PLO forces left Beirut.

During the intervening period, we had continued to receive positive signals from moderate Arab countries in response to the peace plan I announced on September 1, and I had continued trying to persuade Menachem Begin to consider its merits. In a letter to Begin September 5, I said that I was hurt by his continuing public castigation of what I regarded as a serious and realistic peace proposal and his public statements suggesting that the United States—and by implication, that I—was betraying the friendship between our countries. I encouraged him to reconsider the proposal. "The moment has come to breathe new life into a process whose success will insure the permanent security of Israel," I said. "I want us to be together on that journey as we move forward in the cause of peace; this is not a time for recriminations. It's rather a time to explore together how best to move beyond the current perplexing stalemate and to seize the opportunity before us."

I restated my commitment and that of the American people to Israel and urged Begin "in the spirit of our enduring friendship" to take a new look at the proposals "as fair and balanced and this initiative as an appropriate means to launch a fresh start in the Camp David process . . ."